

other issues. We will begin with a review of portal sites in general, an overview of some popular social networking sites, and an examination of the motivation for the development of social networking portals in particular.

1.1 Portals

Web portals provide an important way for collaborating online. The number of portals has steadily increased over the last number of years. And have been very successful as in the case of the Yahoo portal or amazon.com. This section of the paper categorizes and provides an overview of the many different types of portals that have now emerged in various areas business, social and community related areas online.

Enterprise Portals

Enterprise portals enable companies to make the most of their day to day use of company data by managing a company's information online. They help to increase the overall efficiency and business needs of businesses with an online presence. They enable the unlocking of information within and outside of an organization. They maintain, organize, analyze, and dissipate information and also provide a means of integrating many separate and distinct systems that are used within an enterprising organization. They help to manage business knowledge content. They increase the availability of organized and vital content and information presented in a personalized manner to the user online whilst providing a common user interface. Enterprise portals have evolved from Internet portals bearing strong similarities and features to the Yahoo portal. Some examples are IBM and SAP's enterprise portals.

Government Portals

Government portals are built and aimed at citizens to provide them with public information and services online from renewing their car tax to enquiring about their personal taxes. Such jobs that once took up valuable time in queues now take mere minutes online. They make the government and government services more accessible to citizens from one centralized place, helping to inform citizens by